

CHIEFTAINS, QUEENS, AND kinswomen

BIOGRAPHY

QUEEN ELENİ OF ETHIOPIA

Born in 1450, Queen Eleni was among the many African women who played key political roles during the precolonial period. From the Muslim state of Dawaro, she converted to Christianity after her marriage to the Christian king, Zara Yaqob. After he died in 1468, she became regent queen to three successive young kings, including her son Na'od. She possessed exceptional diplomatic skills, and maintained good relations with neighboring Muslim empires via intermarriages and peaceful negotiations.

PRECOLONIAL AFRICA

The women of precolonial African kingdoms commanded great respect. They had roles as queen mothers and queen sisters, princesses, chiefs, and other high-ranking positions in villages and towns, and as warriors and healers. Women were also visible in the economic life of their societies, in areas such as farming, trade, and crafts.

Kinship and power

Societies were based around familial lines and kinship groups. African women had particular responsibilities toward their kinsmen and kinswomen; they offered assistance to their close relatives and performed important rites, such as ceremonies, marriages, and funerals. Within the kinship family, women could occupy various roles—not only as mothers and daughters but also wives and cowives in polygamous marriages. In matrilineages (where bloodlines are traced through the mother), women held formal leadership positions. They generally did not have such key roles in patrilineages (in which lineage is traced through the father), but the more advanced in age they became, the greater their influence was. In both patrilineages and matrilineages, seniority was determined by order of birth rather than gender, so older sisters outranked younger brothers.

Precolonial Africa was notable for the presence of women in key positions in formal governmental structures, as well as for its parallel chieftaincies, which comprised one line of males and another of females. In the West African Yoruba political culture, the Alafin's council (judiciary body) included the *lyalode*, a female representative who was responsible for women's issues. In 19th century Sierra Leone, women could be the heads of towns and subregions.

**Queen Amina of
Zazzau commanded
an army of
20,000
Hausa warriors**

